



**The Policy
Challenge**

AFRICA | NIGERIA 2025

The Policy Challenge Rule Book

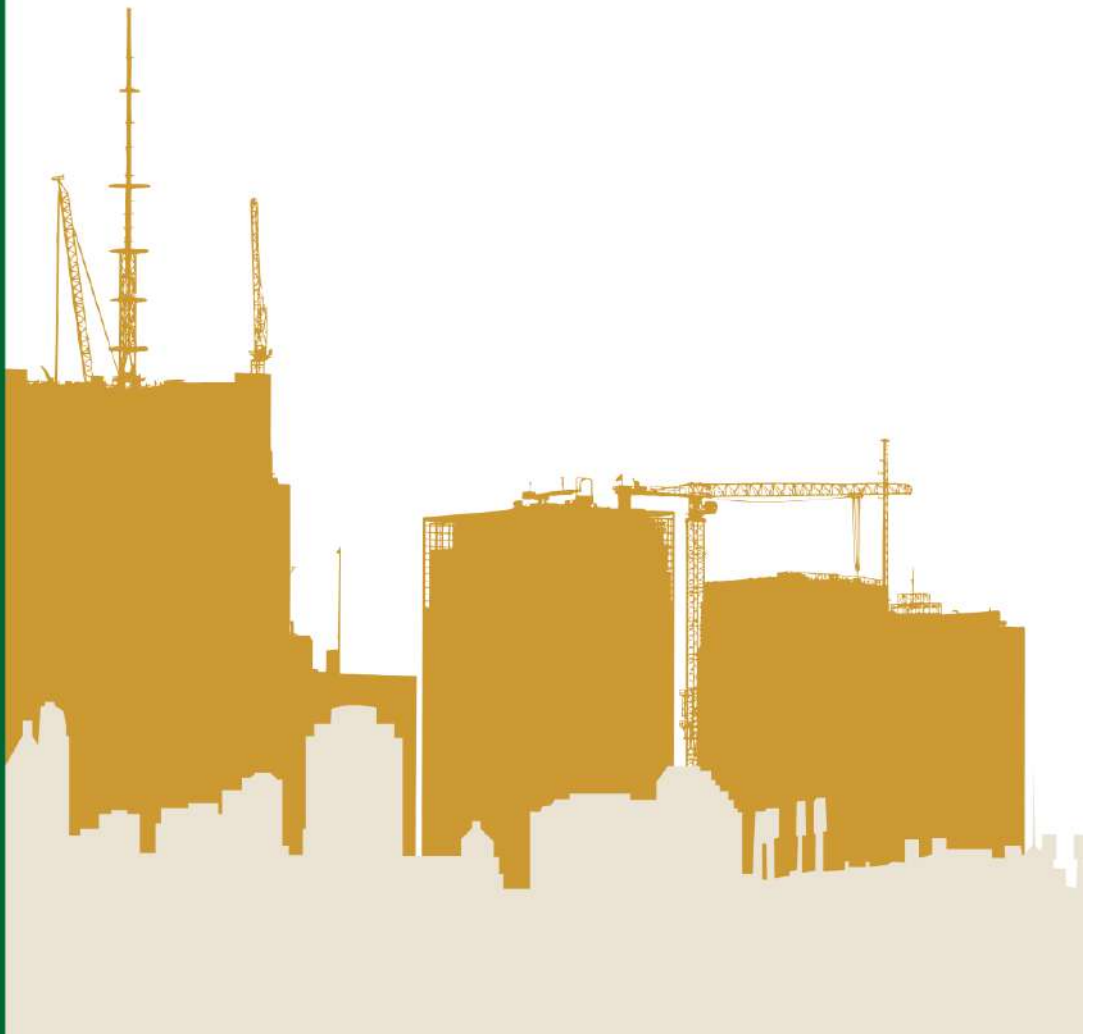


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I. INTRODUCTION

This document will serve as the official rulebook for the 2025 The Policy Challenge (TPC) Nigeria. TPC Nigeria is an initiative of the Future Pathways Development Initiative, a non-governmental organisation focused on policy and governance reforms in Africa. Every effort has been made to develop this rulebook as comprehensive and readable as possible. Kindly consult this document for any questions you may have prior to contacting TPC Nigeria directly. Please note, we maintain the right to amend these rules as deemed appropriate prior to the Challenge but will only do so if absolutely necessary or judged to be in the best interest of the participants. If any questions remain that are not clearly answered in this document, please contact the TPC Nigeria at contact@policychallenge.com. Additional details of the policy conference will be revealed to the selected finalists upon their notification of selection.

II. ELIGIBILITY

The Policy Challenge for Undergraduates is open to submissions from entrants meeting the following eligibility requirements:

- a. Nigerian
- b. At least 18 years of age at the time of the policy conference
- c. Enrolled, either part-time or full-time, as an undergraduate student during the 2024/2025 academic year in any tertiary institution in Nigeria

Additional Circumstances:

- d. Students enrolled in their final year of undergraduate study in the 2024/2025 academic year are considered eligible but should be able to attend the policy conference holding in Abuja on August 12, 2025, if selected as a finalist.

Team Structure:

- e. Interested participants may submit in teams of two or three.
- f. Only one team member needs to submit the proposal, but team members must register to complete group registration.
- g. All team members should meet eligibility criteria and be available to participate in the conference if selected as a finalist team.

Throughout this document, any stipulation applied to participants or finalists is intended to apply to all members of a team submission.

III. SUBMITTING ENTRIES

All entries must be submitted by 11:59 P.M. (central standard time) on May 19, 2025. Entries may be submitted online by uploading proposal via policychallenge.com with the following stipulations:

- The paper must be attached as a .doc or .pdf file
- The paper file should be titled:
[TPC Nigeria Policy Proposal – Group name]
- The paper should meet all formatting requirements described in Section VI.
- Email address(es) provided during registration will serve as the sole means of communication between the TPC Nigeria and the entrant
- information provided is strictly for identification purposes and will not be shared. This information will be withheld from the Review Committee at the time of paper evaluation.

IV. **POLICY PAPER OVERVIEW**

What should submissions address? Entrants must provide a policy proposal that addresses the topic: Rethinking National Unity: Governance Reforms for Strengthening Social Cohesion in Nigeria.

Social cohesion can be thought of as a bond that weaves societies together into a larger corporate community for the benefit of all. The 2022 Nigerian Social Cohesion Index (NSCI) was computed at 39.6%, signifying that social cohesion in Nigeria is at a painful ebb. Low levels of social cohesion make societies prone to internal conflicts and Nigeria has had its fair share of these in the form of a civil war and several episodes of unrest in virtually all parts of the country.

As the world faces increasing levels of violence and insecurity, Goal 16 of the 2030 Agenda – Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions - has become more relevant. Governments, civil society and communities have to work together to build “peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, provide access to justice for all and build effective, accountable and inclusive institutions at all levels.” The selection panel will particularly reward bold but feasible ideas that recognize the nuances of the Nigerian environment and offer proposals on the buy-in of stakeholders.

All papers should contain the following content:

- They should address a national and/or state level policy rather than a local policy.
- They should address laws or public regulations.
- They should be written in a formal style but assume minimal prior knowledge of the reader.
- They should utilize data and academic literature to support arguments made within the paper.
- If the course of action requires a cost, the writer should explain where funds will come from (within the state or national budget, a new tax, etc.).

- They should only contain analysis directly relevant to the policy being proposed.
- They should have a narrow focus and scope, relating to a specific law or regulation or a specific set of laws and regulations that are interconnected.
- They should take the form of a policy proposal and thus include, at minimum:
 - A brief abstract
 - Relevant background information about the subtopic being addressed
 - A statement of current policy and why it is inadequate (if against)/why it is beneficial (if for retaining the policy)
 - A statement of at least two policy options available for addressing this inadequacy (if against)/at least two proposed changes to this policy; with a brief summary of the benefits and drawbacks presented by each option
 - A recommendation for a specific course of action
 - An explanation of why this policy is the preferable alternative, reinforced by evidence and strong argumentation that addresses possible counterarguments
 - A bibliography

Entrants should utilize available data and academic literature to support arguments made within the paper. For a more detailed overview of the evaluation, see Section V below.

V. PAPER EVALUATION OVERVIEW

Weight	Category	Criteria
10%	Background	Does the writer effectively provide background information relevant to the topic at hand? Does the writer describe the relevant status quo for the topic at hand? Does the writer clearly identify plausible, significant inadequacies of the status quo <u>or</u> identify plausible, significant benefits of the status quo?
20%	Proposal	Does the writer describe at least two strong courses of action to resolve the aforementioned inadequacies <u>or</u> two strong proposals to change or eliminate the policies that help maintain the status quo? Does the writer convincingly describe the pros and cons of each alternative? Does the writer clearly and precisely convey what course of action is best? Is the course of action specific and detailed? If the course of action is a change in policy, is it significantly different from the status quo? Is the policy proposal directly relevant to the chosen prompt?
30%	Justification	Does the writer effectively and convincingly argue why the policy proposal will correct the problem presented, or why maintaining the status quo is better policy than accepting a proposed alternative? Does the writer identify and discuss major advantages and disadvantages to adopting the policy proposed? Does the writer effectively address counterarguments? Does the writer identify costs of implementing this policy, and address how these costs will be funded?
15%	Feasibility and Specificity	Does the paper address a specific policy or set of policies that can be reasonably analyzed in a paper of this length? Is the proposal realistic and is its implementation conceivable? Is this policy cost-effective?
25%	Evidence	Does the writer present relevant data to illustrate claims? Does the writer effectively use academic literature to support arguments? Are there many unsupported claims? Are there unnecessary, irrelevant, or inaccurate citations? Are there obvious gaps in research relevant to the policy? How informed does the writer appear to be on the subject matter chosen?

VI. PAPER FORMATTING

- a. All papers should be formatted according to the following criteria:
 - 2,000 – 4,000 words in length, excluding citations. Any paper exceeding the word limit will be subject to disqualification.
 - Times New Roman, 12 pt font
 - Double-spaced
 - Page number centered in footer
 - Standard 1-inch margins on all sides of page
 - Consistent formatting for subsection titles (Letters, numerals, etc.)
- b. Page 1: Cover Page displaying:
 - Group Name
 - Name of Group members
 - University Attended, Expected Year of Graduation
 - Title of Policy Paper
- c. Page 2:
 - Title of Policy Paper
 - Abstract (250 – 350 words)
- d. Page 3: Body of Paper
- e. Last Pages: Bibliography
- f. Footnotes: Times New Roman, 10 pt font, single-spaced

Please do not include any headings or footings beyond the requested page number. Do not include any personal information (name, university, etc.) on any page beyond the cover sheet. An example paper is included in Appendix B.

Failure to adhere to the formatting described above may result in point deductions from the Review Committee's evaluation score.

VII. PAPER EVALUATION PROCEDURE

1. **All entries must be received by May 19, 2025.**
2. All entries received will be assigned an identification number and stripped of their personal identification information. Cover pages will not be printed.
3. The Review Committee will read and score anonymous papers according to the criteria established in Section IV. Members of the Review Committee will have been trained in how papers are to be graded and will report their evaluations to the TPC Nigeria.
4. Six to 10 entrants will be selected as finalists based on the paper evaluation scores. All finalists are invited to participate in a formal conference in Abuja on August 12, 2025.
5. Finalists will be notified no later than July 4, 2025, of their selection to participate in the policy conference. Those who are not selected as finalists will be notified as well.
6. Entrants will have one week from the date of receipt of notification to confirm their intent to participate in the Challenge. TPC Nigeria maintains the right to replace finalists who decline with alternates at its discretion pending circumstances at the time of occurrence.

VIII. **RESPONSIBILITIES AND PROCEDURE FOR GRADING FINALISTS**

After accepting their invitations to participate in the policy conference, finalists will be asked to prepare a presentation to accompany a 15-20 minute presentation of their proposal to be presented to a panel of judges. The style of the presentation is left to the discretion of the finalists but should be kept strictly professional. Presentations should be finalized and emailed or uploaded on the website by 11:59 pm on July 27, 2025. TPC Nigeria will try to accommodate changes made after this deadline prior to the first judging panel but does not guarantee that presentations submitted after this deadline will be accessible. TPC Nigeria is not responsible for providing computer access to any finalists.

1. Each finalist will be invited to make a presentation before a panel of judges and assigned a time slot date to present their policy proposal to a panel of judges.
2. Each finalist will have a **maximum** of 15 minutes to present their proposal using PowerPoint as a visual aid. If participants would like to use an alternative method of visual aid, please send an email to contact@policychallenge.com and we will notify you with our decision. This will be followed by 10 minutes for judges to ask questions.
3. All panel judges will be required to state any familiarity with finalists prior to the presentation. Those with stated relationships will be excused for the round.
- 4. Each finalist's final score will be weighed: 50% paper score and 50% presentation score.**
5. In the case of a tie final score for two or more finalists, the judges from the presentations will convene to rank the tying finalists. No two finalists will tie for a final placement or prize.
6. Cash prizes will be given as detailed in Section XI.
7. At the award ceremony, the top three finalists will be recognized.

IX. RESPONSIBILITIES AND PROCEDURE FOR GRADING FINALISTS

Finalists will be ranked based on final scores. The top three ranked finalists will be recognized and awarded at the Policy Conference. Each will be given 5 minutes to inform the audience of their proposal.

Cash prizes will be given as detailed in Section XI.

X. OVERVIEW OF PRESENTATION EVALUATION

Weight	Category	Criteria
25%	Depth of Knowledge	Does the speaker demonstrate knowledge of the subject matter being analyzed? Does the speaker demonstrate an understanding of the literature on the subject matter? Does the speaker effectively respond to questions proposed by the judges following the presentation?
25%	Completeness of Presentation	Does the speaker discuss the most important relevant aspects of the policy area being analyzed? Does the speaker effectively explain his or her proposal?
25%	Originality and Relevance	Is the speaker's proposal original or unique in some way? Does the proposal directly address a specific policy or related set of policies relevant to one of the prompts? Is the presentation focused on background, research, and analysis relevant to the policy area or proposal?
25%	Presentation	How effective is the speaker? Does the speaker maintain professional demeanor? Does the visual aid provide appropriate and useful visual support for the presentation (graphs, plots, etc.)?

Final score to determine Challenge winner = $0.50 \times \text{Paper Evaluation} + 0.50 \times \text{Presentation}$

XI. PRIZES

- a. 1st Place: ~~N~~2,000,000 + 3-month paid internship
- b. 2nd Place: ~~N~~1,000,000
- c. 3rd Place: ~~N~~750,000
- d. Top ten (10) finalists will have their proposals published in the *2025 Policy Challenge Compendium*

APPENDIX A. TIMELINE OF IMPORTANT DATES

May 19	Submission window closed at 11:59 PM
June 30	Deadline for selection notification of finalists
July 5	Deadline for selected finalists to confirm attendance
July 21	Deadline for submitting PowerPoints for presentation
August 12	TPC Nigeria Public Policy Conference & Award Ceremony